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Left Traumatized: Zizek's Lenin and Politics After 9/11

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The failure on 9/11 was almost entirely one of doctrine_ 'a policy on how to deal with hijackers that was taught to pilots, flight attendants and the public for forty years._

What's amazing is that [the doctrine] changed within an hour of the first plane's takeover...

The doctrinal transformation took place swiftly and decisively... Three average men changed it, almost immediately upon hearing the news via their independent 'intelligence network'... cell phones.

It's called initiative, a civic virtue, part of our national character that doesn't get enough attention. Not from our leaders and certainly not from our enemies

'David Brin, "Some Notes About Calamity... and Opportunity."

Due to our Hellenic traditions, we in the West call the few casualties we suffer from terrorism and surprise 'cowardly,' the frightful losses we inflict through direct assault 'fair.' The real atrocity for the Westerner is not the number of corpses, but the manner in which soldiers died and the protocols under which they are killed. We can comprehend the insanity of a Verdun or Omaha Beach, but never accept the logic of far fewer killed through ambush, terrorism, or the execution of prisoners and noncombatants. Incinerating thousands of Japanese civilians on March 11, 1945, is seen by Westerners as not nearly so gruesome an act as beheading on capture parachuting B-29 fliers.

'Victor Davis Hanson,

Why the West Has Won: Carnage and Culture from Salamis to Vietnam.

If you can't solve a problem, enlarge it.

'U.S. Secretary of Defense Donald Rumsfeld.

In his "Welcome to the Desert of the Real," his essay on the 9/11 attacks, Slavoj Zizek indicts the left for a failure to address the event in an adequate way: "The predominant reaction of European, but also American Leftists was nothing less than scandalous... all imaginable stupidities were said and written" (10). Among the charges: "Schadenfreude: the US got what it deserved"; a failure to fully solidarize with the victims (not to mention 'Zizek doesn't the rescuers) "since this would mean supporting US imperialism"; "in the weeks following the bombing, it reverted to the old mantra 'Give peace a chance! War does not stop violence!' 'a true case of hysterical precipitation, reacting to something that will not even happen in the expected form." Zizek was being generous: his reference to the "petty and miserable mathematics" ("what are the 6000 dead against millions in Ruanda, Congo, etc."), for example, hardly captures the grotesque casualty watch in which once the reported Afghani casualty number went higher than the WTC number, moral "victory" could be declared.

> One should therefore turn around the standard reading according to which the WTC explosions

While Zizek says that the point is not "to play a pseudo-postmodern game of reducing the WTC o

> "Lenin" is not the nostalgic name for old dogmatic certainty; quite on the contrary, to put in-becoming, the Lenin whose fundamental experience was that of being thrown into a catastrophe.

Lenin, for Žižek, signifies the "right to truth" over the "right to narrate" (10), to a "_uni-

> to _repeat_ Lenin does NOT mean a _return_ to Lenin'to repeat Lenin is to accept that "Lenin

Lenin, or, rather, our experience of Lenin "as irrelevant, 'out of sync' with our postmodern t

> As a member of the Central Committee of the Party and a deputy in the Duma, Malinovsky was :

The lesson here is that a genuine political space is one in which even your own worst enemy, :

> The only criterion \[of the political act\] is the absolutely _inherent_ one: that of the _circuit between the present and the future, we are'as if by Grace'for a brief time allowed to a

It would be hard to improve on this definition of what Lenin called "ultra-leftism." The unique

> The institution of slavery is only mentioned in the Constitution of the United States two or

Lincoln is here arguing against the claim that the Founders had obviously meant to approve of

> The purpose was that in our constitution, which it was hoped as is still hoped will endure :

According to this strange claim, the word "slavery" was excluded from the Constitution so that up just make things even worse, and be even more certain to incriminate the "fathers"?

Notes

I should also mention here Judith Butler's "Guant'namo Limbo" in the April 1 issue of *The Nation*, which I saw after I wrote this essay. Here, Butler does offer a theoretical accounting. Drawing upon an argument she borrowed from Giorgio Agamben in her *Excitable Speech* to the effect that "states of exception" are becoming the "norm" in late modern Western societies increasingly governed by "bio-power," she inquires into the "undecided" (but really undecidable?) legal status of the Taliban and Al-Qaeda prisoners held by the U.S. Prisoner of war? Unlawful combatant? Subject to a duly constituted international tribunal? Ad hoc U.S. military tribunal? This is what has become of a deconstructive politics of the performative: legalistic haggling. Meanwhile, Butler notes-pointing to the seriousness of this issue-that "the war is not over; it appears that it will now be continued in such places as Indonesia, Iraq, North Korea, Iran Pakistan and the Philippines" (23). No need to comment on that! Unless we take her entire essay as a comment: U.S. goals and actions in the war are beneath contempt, only worth mentioning so as to expose their patent cynicism and absurdity. Meanwhile, those for whom this is axiomatic should contribute to the inevitable unraveling of this latest application of bio-power, which is sure to produce new sites of counter-power. Then it will be possible to return to the more serious business of generating new and ever more ethereal "rights." Of course, the question of the Al-Qaeda prisoners can be settled rather easily: release any who will sign a-carefully prepared, yet easily modified for specific cases-confession and/or statement denouncing,

in requisite detail, Bin Laden, his followers and doctrines. Those who refuse provide evidence that they are unlawful combatants who cannot safely be guaranteed the rights and protections of prisoners of war. Of course, this assumes the hegemony of the civilized/barbaric binary (Butler's real complaint, as she argues for hyper-civilized treatment for the prisoners): "civilization" is where explicit political actions (a public position-taking) can resolve the inevitable undecidable areas of the law. * * *

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